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Rinku Singh confesses that, as a child, he had a difficult time comprehending why his father was almost never home. Days would pass, then weeks, months, as Singh grew up with his large family in a one-bedroom home in Holpur, a village in Uttar Pradesh's Bhadohi district. "But when I grew up, I understood that he was the only man in our family who was providing us three meals a day, a roof over our heads," says Singh, speaking to INDIA TODAY over Zoom. "That's when I made the decision to make my father and mother's life better. I never needed motivation outside of my dad," he says. "He is my hero." Singh's father was a truck driver, spending many of his nights on the road, often travelling on hazardous routes across north India.

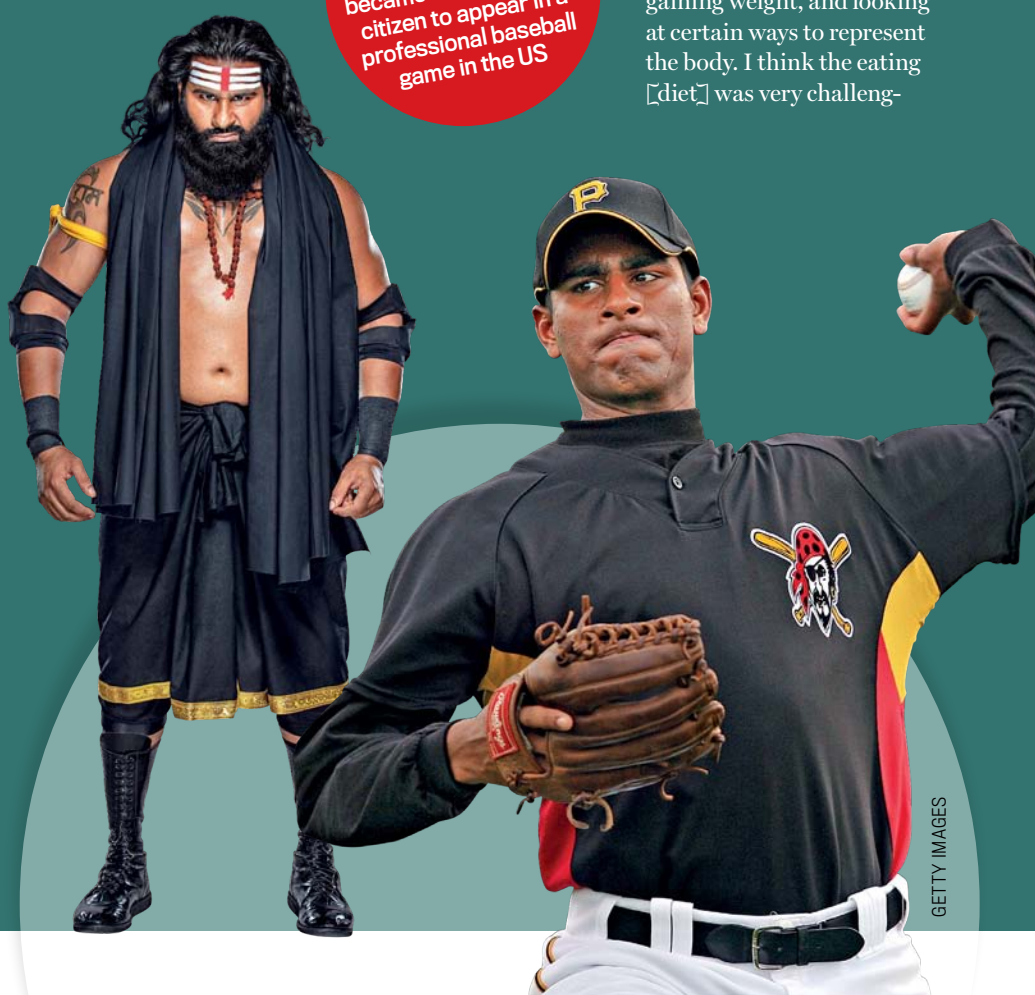
Soon, Singh would travel, too. First, he threw javelins; then, he threw baseballs; and now, he throws wrestling opponents outside the confines of the ring. Singh's ring persona is Veer Mahaan, one of the few Indian superstars to make the breakthrough with World Wrestling Entertainment (WWE), the world's most dominant professional wrestling promotion. Now, he is better known for his ferocious roars, for his long locks and beard, for the trademark *tripundra* on his forehead, and the cervical clutch that beats opponents into submission.

While pursuing track and field as a teenager, Singh faced a life-changing fork in the road when he bested over 37,000 other contestants to win the baseball-based reality TV show *Million Dollar Arm*. Like his father before him, work and opportunity uprooted Singh—taking him and runner-up Dinesh Patel to Los Angeles to train as baseball pitchers.

Playing for the Pittsburgh Pirates, Singh made history by becoming the first Indian citizen to appear in a professional baseball game in the US. Singh and Patel's story was 'Disneyfied' on the big screen with the 2014 film *Million Dollar Arm*. Both pitchers had discovered baseball late in life, and, eventually, the fairy-tale came to an end. Patel returned to India and became a national-level javelin thrower. Meanwhile, Singh, after a few more baseball stops in minor leagues, Australia and the Dominican Republic, took another leap of faith: In 2018, he signed a contract with the WWE to enter the world of professional wrestling, migrating from the 'diamond' to the 'squared circle'.

"My goal has always been to help the community," says Singh about his journey. "I'm 33 and this is the third career change for me. As long as I'm able to represent the nation and represent its culture and tradition, I'll keep going." One of the biggest challenges for Singh was to change his physical build. He was always relatively tall (6-feet-3), but for his turn as a pro wrestler, he also bulked up to 125 kg to perform against some of the most powerful opponents in the ring. "It was more about gaining weight, and looking at certain ways to represent the body. I think the eating [diet] was very challeng-

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